

CONSUMPTION

SEASON'S TIDINGS

The festive season was bright for automakers and realtors, but sales in certain consumer goods segments remained flat

BY ARNAB DUTTA

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► **IT'S THAT HEADY** time of the year when manufacturers line up offers to lure customers who are generally easier with their wallets, thanks to a string of festivals, in anticipation of bumper sales in the run-up to the end of the calendar year. While a majority of them—from makers of washing machines and television sets to two-wheelers and passenger cars—have reported a festive boost, this season has left some high and dry.

During the 40-odd-day festive period—between early October and mid-November—while sales of automobiles and television sets surged significantly, categories like

PREMIUM PUSH
Industry insiders say growth in the white goods space has been led by premium products, and the mass-market segment has remained flat

home appliances remained flat.

Take the country's vast automotive sector, for instance. After touching a new high in 2022, sales surged to a new record of about 3.8 million units in the festive season, up from some 3.2 million in the corresponding period last year. While the two-wheeler segment—the largest in terms of number of units sold—has been a major cause of concern for most manufacturers, with rural consumers shying away from purchases, this time it was this segment that drove the growth of the sector, says Manish Raj Singhania, President of the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA).

“These are record numbers. Consumers from the rural market, which accounts for 70 per cent of the two-wheeler sales in India, flocked to dealerships during the festive period. Passenger vehicle sales also scaled a new high, crossing 500,000 units for the first time in history,” Singhania tells *BT*. Buoyancy in the auto sector was also reflected in sales of three-wheelers, used mostly for commercial purposes, which rose to 142,875 units in the season, up 41 per cent from last year.

Last year, the availability of vehicles at the dealers' end was an issue that resulted in prolonged waiting times and, eventually, impacted sales. This time, however, such bottlenecks were managed. “More-



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